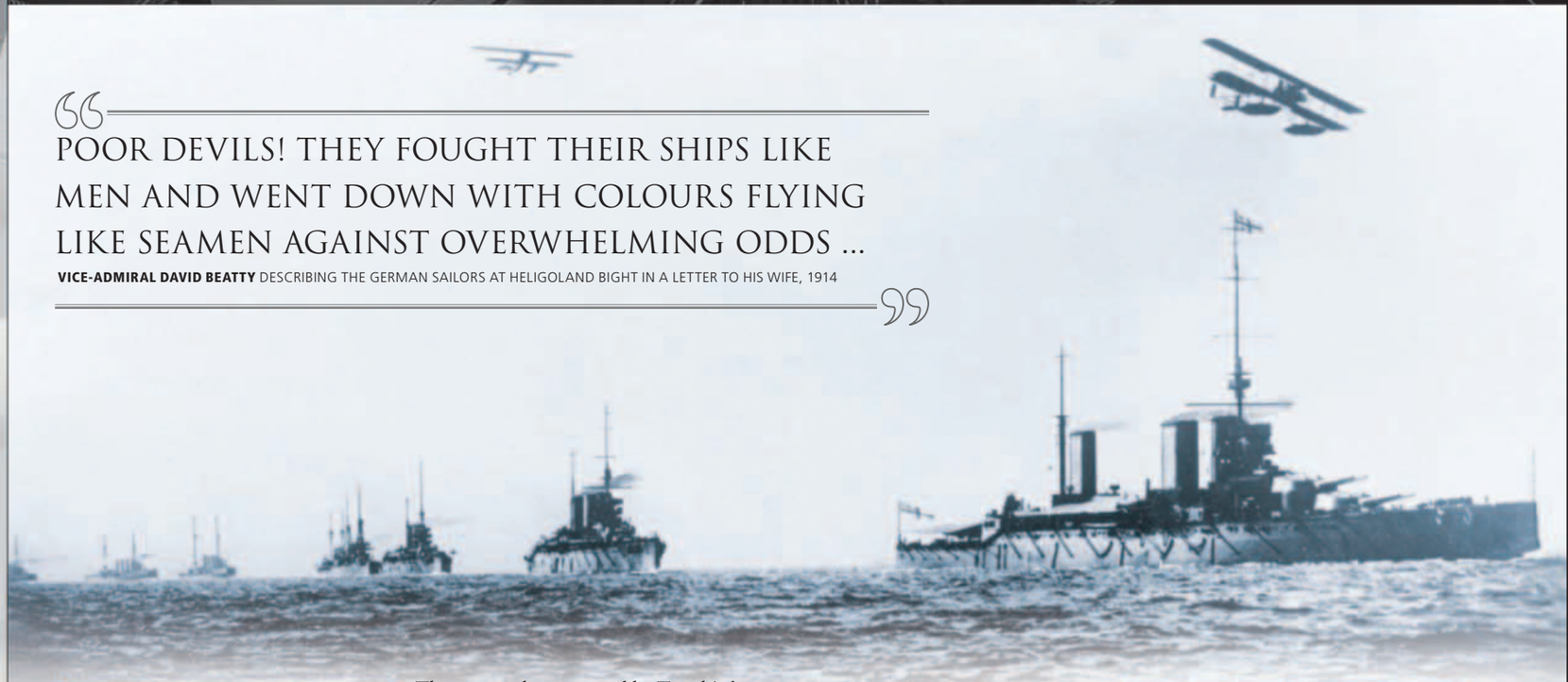
WARSHIP BATTLES 1914–18

MUCH OF THE NAVAL ACTION early in World War I concerned the Royal Navy's efforts to track down German surface raiders, which posed a serious threat to Allied shipping. After the British victory over Admiral Graf von Spee's squadron at the Falklands in December 1914, German commerce raiding was restricted to submarines, the U-boats proving a fearful menace for merchant shipping and warships alike (see pp 268-269). An attempt to use Allied naval power to decisive effect against Germany's ally Turkey in the Dardanelles was a painful failure. Meanwhile, for almost two years the Royal Navy's Grand Fleet and the German High Seas Fleet, stationed at opposite ends of the North Sea, did not meet. After an early reverse at the Heligoland Bight, the Kaiser forbade his fleet to venture into the North Sea, although this prohibition was not absolutely respected. Probing raids by German squadrons met with some success, despite a serious setback at the Dogger Bank, before the British at last trapped their opponents into a full-scale fleet engagement at Jutland in May 1916—without, however, achieving the victory which Britain craved.

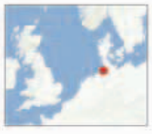
> "POOR DEVILS! THEY FOUGHT THEIR SHIPS LIKE MEN AND WENT DOWN WITH COLOURS FLYING LIKE SEAMEN AGAINST OVERWHELMING ODDS ..."
>
> **VICE-ADMIRAL DAVID BEATTY** DESCRIBING THE GERMAN SAILORS AT HELIGOLAND BIGHT IN A LETTER TO HIS WIFE, 1914



Battlecruisers in line ahead
A column of Royal Navy warships is led by *Queen Mary* and *Princess Royal* of the First Battlecruiser Squadron, victorious at Heligoland Bight.

WORLD WAR I

HELIGOLAND BIGHT



Date August 28, 1914
Forces British: 5 battlecruisers, 8 light cruisers, 31 destroyers, 3 submarines; Germans: 6 light cruisers, 19 torpedo boats
Losses British: none; Germans: 3 light cruisers, 1 torpedo boat
Location Heligoland Bight, northern Germany

Commodore Roger Keyes, in command of British submarines based at Harwich, conceived a plan for an impudent raid on German ships on patrol near their naval base at Heligoland. The raid was to be carried out by the light cruisers and destroyers of Commodore Reginald Tyrwhitt's Harwich Force, along with Keyes' submarines. It was decided at the last minute to provide back-up for the raid from Vice-Admiral David Beatty's 1st Battlecruiser Squadron and the 1st Light Cruiser Squadron of Commodore William Goodenough.

As Keyes had planned, early on the morning of August 28, the presence of British submarines off Heligoland was detected by the Germans, who promptly sent out a flotilla of torpedo boats. These were then engaged by Tyrwhitt's destroyers and two light cruisers, *Arethusa* and *Fearless*. Fought in mist, the ensuing battle was characterized by confusion on both sides. The German light cruisers *Stettin* and *Frauenlob* arrived on the scene and duelled with *Fearless* and *Arethusa* respectively. *Arethusa*, with Tyrwhitt on board, suffered heavy damage and withdrew to attempt repairs. Four more German light cruisers turned up, attacking in an uncoordinated fashion as Tyrrwhitt's destroyers screened *Arethusa*.

Fortunately for the British, the arrival of Goodenough's light cruisers, followed by Beatty's battlecruisers, swung the balance of forces decisively in their favour. Rear-Admiral Leberecht Maass's *Mainz* was sunk after being caught between the Harwich Force destroyers and Goodenough's cruisers. The light cruisers *Köln* and *Ariadne* were destroyed by the heavy guns of Beatty's *Lion*, looming unexpectedly upon them out of the mist. The British withdrew across the North Sea, *Arethusa* reaching home under tow.

Despite "friendly fire" incidents resulting from poor communication and worrying malfunctions of guns and fire-control systems, the British had scored an unquestionable victory, achieved with great boldness in German home waters.



QF 3-pounder Hotchkiss
Pedestal-mounted Quick Firing (QF) 3-pounders were common anti-torpedo boat guns on British cruisers at the start of the war, but were soon found to be too light to be very effective.

1863–1928

REINHARD SCHEER

GERMAN ADMIRAL

Born in Obernkirchen, Hanover, Scheer joined the Imperial German Navy in 1879. By 1907 he had risen to be chief of staff of the High Seas Fleet. On the outbreak of World War I he advocated the use of surface ships to lure British warships into the path of submarines lying in ambush. On being promoted to Admiral of the Fleet in 1916, he used a similar tactic at Jutland. The skill of his maneuvers in the battle enabled the German fleet to escape and even to claim victory.

